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Shifting the ground beneath Singapore literature: Archipelagic thinking in Isa Kamari's *Rawa* and Rachel Heng's *The Great Reclamation*

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ABSTRACT
This article shows how archipelagic thinking discloses the blind spots of a land-focused rationality and praxis, which has underpinned dominant conceptualizations of nationhood in Singapore, by alerting us to the potential of a wider horizon than the one within which we typically situate and understand Singapore literature. It seeks to interrogate how choices that impact knowledge production, national identity, and emotional attachment to place come to be strategically made and normalized by examining two Singapore novels: Isa Kamari's *Rawa* ([2009] 2013), originally written in Malay, and Rachel Heng's *The Great Reclamation* (2023). Largely realist in style but with distinct fantastical elements, both novels rely on the ocean and littoral place-making for affective, thematic, and symbolic significance. Using archipelagic thinking, they critically examine the territorial and spatial imaginary linked to Singapore's postcolonial nation-building by excavating forgotten histories, activating alternative mobilities, and reclaiming different modes of knowing.

KEYWORDS
Singapore literature; archipelagic thinking; Orang Seletar; land reclamation; magic realism; *Rawa: The Great Reclamation*

Introduction: Island and archipelago

In 1998, the then Indonesian President, B.J. Habibie, referred to Singapore as a "little red dot" when expressing his displeasure at what he perceived to be the city state's lack of support for its much larger archipelago-nation neighbour in the wake of the Asian Financial Crisis. Since then, the term has been rehabilitated and embraced by Singaporeans to connote Singapore's centrality as an important hub or node in global networks of finance, technology, trade, and information, even if it continues to underline the inescapable fact of Singapore's small geographical size and lack of natural resources. Positive or negative, the phrase operates in the popular imagination to stabilize and fix Singapore's territorial identity and to emphasize its bounded integrity despite the fact that the nation is technically composed of one main island and over 60 smaller islands and islets, some already amalgamated. In the contemporary public imagination, Singapore's older geopolitical history as part of the Riau-Lingga archipelago and

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Sultanate has long been eclipsed by its post-1965 national story which is dominated by the failure of its merger with Malaysia.[1]

As a postcolonial nation, the historical period of decolonization and nation-building in Singapore typically brings to mind images of construction and building on terra firma, whether this be of public housing, large-scale industries, or key infrastructure. Such images reinforce Singapore's official narrative of progress which is underpinned by particular ways of conceiving space and time that privilege land-based epistemologies and distinct notions about postcolonial national sovereignty. This article argues that Singapore literature serves as a semi-autonomous site for imagining the nation otherwise. Using archipelagic thinking as a conceptual frame, I show how two contemporary novels invest in the meaning-making potential and history of the sea and littoral areas often elided by the island city state's official historical narrative of its postcolonial development. Largely realist in style but with distinct fantastical elements, the novels are Isa Kamari's ([2009] 2013) *Rawa*, originally written in Malay and translated into English in 2013, and Rachel Heng's (2023) *The Great Reclamation*. *Rawa* depicts the world of the Orang Seletar, an indigenous, seafaring people displaced by the nation state's urban development when they lost navigational access to the waterways between Singapore and Johor that sustained their traditional way of life. *The Great Reclamation* traces the story of Ah Boon, a young boy from a fishing family whose fantastical ability to discover mysterious islands initially proves beneficial to his local community but ultimately leads to tragic loss when he becomes part of the state machinery in the new postcolonial government. Relying on the sea and littoral place-making for affective, thematic, and symbolic significance, the novels may be said to be "projects located at the intersection of the littoral and the literary" (Volland 2022, 340). Both novels critically examine the territorial and spatial imaginary linked to Singapore's postcolonial nation-building by excavating forgotten histories, activating alternative mobilities, and reclaiming different modes of knowing.

Archipelagic thinking as an alternative epistemological mode: Implications for the study of anglophone Singapore literature

A considerable body of scholarship in multidisciplinary island and archipelago studies, which takes into account geographical realities and the lived experiences of islanders as well as the metaphorical and symbolic affordances of islands, already exists. In *Contemporary Archipelagic Thinking*, Michelle Stephens and Yolanda San Miguel (2020) argue how the archipelagic – based on a material and tangible referent – emphasizes the embodied experience of space while also "[encouraging] us to think about how multisited, multifocal experiences contribute to the temporary articulation of historical, political and symbolical imaginaries" (20). Similarly, "Envisioning the Archipelago" advocates using the island and the archipelago as models for rethinking the nature of relationality, connections, and affiliations to "[unsettle] the imperial binaries of land and water, island and continent/mainland" (Stratford et al. 2011, 124). By recasting conventional thinking about "islands in a far sea" as a "sea of islands" (Hau'ofa 1993, 5), archipelagic thinking directs critical attention to the circulation, ebb, and flow of people, ideas, and goods, thus

complicating ethnocentric or nationalist claims to cultural singularity, isolation, and internal homogeneity. It deliberately focuses on the "structuring tension" (Stephens and Miguel 2020, 6) between land and sea in order to examine competing historical articulations of space, time, and ecological world views, especially those by marginalized constituencies.

Scholarship on archipelagic thinking owes a debt to francophone Martinician writer and theorist Edouard Glissant (1928–2011) who did much to harness the heuristic potential of the archipelago form to rethink the intellectual tradition of the west and some of the most commonplace ideas about cultural change. Using the geography and history of the Antilles as a starting point, Glissant theorizes about the "archipelagic imagination", comparing it to relationality embodied in the rhizome. According to Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari (1987), the rhizomatic structure privileges assemblages and lateral operations rather than the linear and hierarchical unidimensionality of the arboreal system. They note that the "tree is filiation, but the rhizome is alliance, uniquely alliance. The tree imposes the verb 'to be', but the fabric of the rhizome is the conjunction, 'and ... and'" (25). Building on Deleuze and Guattari's preference for the rhizome over the "totalitarian root" (Glissant 1990, 11), Glissant writes that "rhizomatic thought is the principle behind what I call the Poetics of Relation, in which each and every identity is extended through a relationship with the Other" (11). The root is associated with what Glissant considers "continental frameworks that assume synthesis, unity, and coherence as organic to human social experiences" while "the archipelagic [is] a spatial and symbolic allegory of the theory of relation conceived as differences that interact, collide, and coexist through time and space" (Stephens and Miguel 2020, 5). In this way, archipelagic and rhizomatic models of thought seek to refute single-minded master narratives with their linearity, teleologies, and emphasis on consistency by privileging instead multiplicity, decentredness, and ambiguity (Wiedorn 2018). To Glissant, this constitutes a specific ethics of relation especially suited to a modern, globalized world galvanized by accelerated flows of ideas and movement of peoples where effectively navigating cultural differences and forms of syncretism in contact zones is a critical imperative.

How then might the relational emphasis of archipelagic thinking shift our understanding and interpretation of anglophone Singapore literature? In her discussion of Singapore's anglophone literary tradition, Shirley Geok-lin Lim (2003) has observed how applying a rhizomatic paradigm tellingly reveals the elision of the Southeast Asian region in the island nation's cultural imaginary of itself, where "region" is understood "both in the sense of territorial regionalism and epistemological and other affiliative proximities" (206). Examining anglophone Singapore literature from the 1990s, she notes how the preference for a self-contained localism over a regional identity promoted identification with rigid borders and the entrenchment of an oversimplified "nation versus the West" binary. Such a preference was reflected as well in publishing and in literary criticism, foreclosing possibilities for forms of cultural multiplicity that might exceed the state-imposed model of managed diversity. More recently, Cheryl Julia Lee (2023) has also noted the critical potential of archipelagic thinking for anglophone Southeast Asian literary studies. Such thinking helps to "rewrite the extant metageographical construct of Southeast Asia" (499), bringing into view social groups, associations, and knowledges historically disavowed by the area's colonial and postcolonial regimes, which tended to

use the idea of national differences to promote internal (national) homogeneity while operating within the wider global frame of centre–periphery relations.

In contrast to the methodological nationalism of much literary criticism pertaining to anglophone Singapore literature, archipelagic thinking features more prominently in adjacent fields of study such as the Malay-language literature and scholarship of the Malay World (usually referring to the area encompassing present-day Singapore, Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand, the Philippines, and Brunei) as well as sinophone literature of Nanyang or the South Seas. The Malay World is linked to the heyday of the Melaka Sultanate as a regional power and important trading hub for merchants from the Malay Archipelago, India, China, and the Middle East in the 15th century. It encompasses pre-colonial historical patterns of interaction which created specific sociopolitical and cultural groupings. Thus, historicized, textual examinations of the Malay World bring to the fore a less nation-based conceptualization of cultural flow and relational influences. Such studies seek to "recover a sense of regional connectedness and sensibility, to anchor the region's history in the face of the massive transformations of the modern era" (Harper 2013, 279). The Malay World is sometimes referred to by its synonym or close conceptual cognate "Nusantara", a Sanskrit-derived word inextricable from the understanding of archipelago (Evers 2016, 4) or "tanah air". The latter Malay term, meaning literally land and sea space, offers a geospatial formation that foregrounds the sea and marks the littoral as a shifting but significant boundary for critical consideration. Malay World writing and scholarship revolve around "a cultural geography constituted by the flow of people, texts, languages and commodities whose spatial dimensions vary across time" (Mandal 2016, 69) as compared to anglophone literary production in Singapore which is strongly influenced by British colonialism and postcolonial developments such as the adoption of English as a lingua franca.

Similarly, sinophone literary scholarship of the Nanyang or the South Seas, as Southeast Asia is often referred to by Chinese-language writers, also offers other ways of thinking about national and transnational cultures and identities. Alluding to Glissant and national literatures in the Caribbean archipelago, Brian Bernards (2016) stresses the salience of archipelagic thinking to literary production by sinophone Southeast Asian writers in the 20th century. He writes:

> the archipelagic consciousness imagines national "oneness" as a "fluid and open" network of "change and exchange" between lands connected (rather than isolated) by seas. Postcolonial authors not only re-energize the archipelagic imagination of the national culture but also revive transcultural affinities that cross and transgress the boundaries imposed by colonial and national regimes in their regions. (13)

By emphasizing littoral peripheries, mobilities, and maritime exchanges, the archipelagic offers potentially new relationalities and vantage points from which to re-examine national cultures and processes of creolization in Singapore and other parts of Southeast Asia. In sinophone literature, the archipelagic metaphor has enabled Malaysia-born Chinese writer and scholar Ng Kim Chew to theorize the differentiated nature of world literary space and cultural production. According to sinophone scholar Cheow Thia Chan (2023), Ng "casts Mahua literature as a seldom explored sociohistorical laboratory that nurtures consequential diversity for literature of and in the world despite its enduring precarity" (7). His evocative idea of

a "Literary Galapagos archipelago" (Chan 2023, 6) that incorporates *mahua* or Malayan and Malaysian sinophone literature describes literary production on the periphery of world literature and Chinese-language literature that is rich and fruitful in aesthetic innovation, with potentially transformative consequences for a global literary ecology.

For Malay World and sinophone Nanyang studies, then, archipelagic thinking has enabled comparative literary analyses and the tracing of what Sanjay Subrahmanyam has called "connected histories" (cited by Gabriel and Rosa 2016, 5), which disclose how boundaries resulting from European imperialism's carving up of the archipelago into competing spheres of influence and then as nationalist frames "repress[ed] the profoundly multi-scalar histories and genealogies of nations" (5). The archipelagic frame enables a decolonial perspective of Singapore in relation to older regional political networks and systems, displacing the Eurocentric version of history that has rendered indigenous groups invisible and dominated the island nation's story. This article applies critical pressure to a conception of Singapore literature underpinned by the doxological national imaginary in order to attend more closely to the rooting processes of national identity formation and the way in which fixity has replaced variety and multiplicity. Archipelagic thinking alerts us to the potential of a wider horizon than the one within which we typically situate Singapore literature, especially its writing in English, offering an opportunity for interrogating how choices that impact knowledge production, national identity, and emotional attachment to place come to be strategically made and normalized. Given how Singapore's multilingual history reveals its transborder connections to various ethnic groups in the region, it follows that archipelagic thinking must include a concerted attempt to read Singapore literature comparatively across two or more of the four language streams and literary traditions of Malay, Chinese, Tamil, and English.[2] The decision in this article to discuss a translated Malay novel alongside one written in English and marketed from the west to a global audience is an uncommon move in Singapore literary criticism. But it draws attention to the role of translation and underscores the obvious though often ignored point that texts from Singapore's non-English national languages need to be translated before they can shift epistemological paradigms since they have to first enter the anglophone cultural imaginary in a substantive way. The move also challenges the sense of exceptionalism and privilege with which anglophone Singapore literature tends to be treated vis-à-vis literature written in the other official languages.

The two Singapore novels examined in this article evoke different dimensions of archipelagic thinking for consideration. Valorizing the Orang Seletar and their nomadic culture and values, Isa's *Rawa* reminds us of Singapore's archipelagic reality, a geographical fact and spatial imaginary almost wholly erased by the state's dominant account of nation-building and modernization. In comparison to the recuperation of Singaporean and regional history undertaken in *Rawa*, Heng's *The Great Reclamation* relies on the fantastical trope of appearing and vanishing islands – an unmappable archipelago – to question the land-focused logic of nation-building which is premised on control over scarce territory and a totalizing approach to urban planning. National sovereignty is based on separatism, non-contiguity of space, and notions of territorial integrity. The connotations of land – concreteness and solidity – are seen to reify a hard-nosed rationality and realistic pragmatism

associated with the authoritarian postcolonial ethic of Singapore's ruling PAP (People's Action Party) government.

Rawa

The Malay-language novel *Rawa* by Isa shines a light on the hidden history of the Orang Seletar, an indigenous people who once lived and navigated the waters of the Seletar River area in Singapore as well as the other estuaries, tributaries, rivers, and straits around Singapore and Johor, alongside the Orang Kallang. Both groups are perhaps more familiarly known as the Orang Laut, an umbrella term referring to the various groups of indigenous people of Singapore and Johor. Living in "the labyrinth of tidal channels and waterways in the mangrove swamps of the Riau islands and the southeast coast of Sumatra" (Kwa et al. 2019, 70), these sea nomads were skilled navigators who served historically as the naval warriors of the sultans in Melaka, and later Johor, after the fall of the Melaka Sultanate in 1511. Their presence is recorded in the *Sejarah Melayu* as well as in various Portuguese and Dutch documents of the 16th and 17th centuries. Over the course of the 19th and most of the 20th centuries, the Orang Seletar in Singapore were progressively displaced from Seletar as mangrove areas in the north of the island were cleared for plantations, a military airbase was constructed in the area in the early 20th century, and a dam was built. The Seletar people either moved to Johor where the Sultan of Johor had allowed them to settle or were assimilated into Singapore society as Malays, abandoning their nomadic way of life and traditional seafaring ways. The story of the Orang Seletar resembles other narratives of displacement and environmental degradation faced by indigenous groups throughout Southeast Asia.[3] To the authorities and modern administrative state, the Orang Seletar's reluctance to "modernize" posed several problems; their nomadic existence, and their lack of official documents of citizenship like birth certificates and identity cards, rendered them at odds with modern life and its bureaucratic trappings. They were obstacles to the redevelopment of the land and coast called for by capitalist nation-building. At the same time, their marginalization and knowledge of waterways meant they could also be driven to illegal activity such as smuggling.

In his novel, Isa emphasizes how the history of the original people of Singapore has been all but lost in modern consciousness, erased by the city state's dominant story of nation-building and its fundamentally land-related epistemology. The novel presents a split narrative frame, shuttling back and forth between the main protagonist Rawa's early life in the middle decades of the 20th century and the narrative "present" where, as an old man and a widower, he moves to a Singapore he hardly recognizes to live with his daughter, son-in-law, and grandson, Hassan. In his lifetime, Rawa has gone from living on a houseboat in Seletar to being resettled in Johor. His experience is emblematic of the Orang Seletar, and the account of his life as told to his grandson is "fact-checked", as it were, in the novel against the young boy's knowledge from history textbooks and the documentary about Singapore he watched on TV. The word "Rawa", meaning literally "swamp" or "marsh", is both the name of the main character and a reference to the traditional area traversed by the Orang Seletar. According to the narrator, "Rawa is the name of the land. The name also refers to its waters. Rawa is the wind. It is the name he

has lived with for 70 years. He is Rawa, in name and in essence" (Isa [2009] 2013, 1). An all-encompassing notion including even the air associated with a location, "rawa" exceeds the conventional idea of place.

The Orang Seletar's more holistic and multi-sensory conceptualization of place is contrasted in the novel with the territorial dispute between Singapore and Malaysia over Pedra Branca, also known as Batu Puteh in Malay. Pedra Branca is a small but strategic outcrop of rocky land close to the eastern entrance of the Singapore strait over which both nation states have asserted territorial control.[4] In the "Prologue" to the novel, Hassan reads about the decision by the International Court of Justice in the Hague to grant Singapore sovereignty over Pedra Branca. The news causes him to "smile cynically" and dismiss the "political wrangling" (Isa [2009] 2013, 4) between the countries: "In his heart, the island is not Batu Puteh or Pedra Branca, but Rawa" (4). Hassan regards the disputed outcrop as an intrinsic and organic part of the natural seascape that cannot be possessed. In contrast, questions of ownership, property, sovereignty, and territorial rights are fundamentally land-based concepts, including the idea of territorial waters as an extension of the land. Competing meanings of place thus frame the novel from the start as the narrative proceeds to show how the Orang Seletar's traditional world view and sense of cultural identity come progressively under pressure, first by the colonial government machinery and then the postcolonial nation state.

As the novel stresses, one of the key reasons for the gradual loss of the Orang Seletar's access to mobility is the Causeway "which split the straits in two permanently" (Isa [2009] 2013, 103) while linking Singapore to peninsular Malaysia. Completed by the British in 1924, the Causeway is a raised land-crossing across the Strait of Johor made up of solid fill. Now it is one of the world's busiest border-crossings and is seen as a vital artery of trade and movement as well as a symbol of strong ties between the two sovereign nations. When it was first built, however, it acted to impede the Orang Seletar's movement and navigation of the surrounding waterways and tributaries. As Rawa's Orang Kallang friend Ayong explains, "the causeway facilitates land dwellers, but it has made life very difficult for us sea people" (12). In the 1980s, further state control of the water around and in Singapore resulted in the building of the Yishun dam which transformed the Seletar River into the Lower Seletar Reservoir as part of creating catchment areas for the nation's water supply. This led to the displacement of the Orang Seletar, a historical fact represented in the novel by Rawa and his wife Temah's eventual resettlement in Johor.

The inability of the modern state to accommodate the Orang Seletar's mode of existence is brought sharply into focus again when Rawa attempts to sail to Pedra Branca. Undertaking the sail ostensibly to reclaim his "inheritance" – a ring given by the Sultan of Johor to his father, stolen by his friend Ayong, and buried on the island – Rawa's trip has a tragic outcome. He is badly injured in a collision with a ship, sent to a hospital in Singapore, and separated from Temah for a few months with no money, documents, or means of contacting her. Ensnaring him further in the apparatus of state and bureaucratic systems he is ill-equipped to navigate, the episode reinforces the novel's representation of the Orang Seletar as increasingly anachronistic subjects in Singapore's official narrative of progress and the powerless victims of history.

Yet the text also challenges the postcolonial nation's developmental logics by ironically showing how the Orang Seletar's flexible approach towards social relations with others as part of an archipelagic sense of interconnectedness could

serve as a model for interaction and peaceful coexistence in a modern multiracial nation. In their youth, Rawa and his friend Ayong would forage and harvest "bakau and nyireh, nipah palm fronds for roofing, and pandan for mats" (Isa [2009] 2013, 10). They would barter their catch of seafood and natural resources for whatever else they needed. Not originally Muslim, the Orang Seletar associated with neighbouring Chinese farmers, the Orang Asli, as well as other Malays. In the novel, the Orang Seletar's mobile, subsistent way of life is associated with an openness to others borne out of mutual reliance and exchange, rather than ownership. In Rawa's view:

> To Seletar folk, the universe was large enough for everyone. There was no need to jostle and fight over it. The existence of villages of people of many races and creeds along the seventeen rivers flowing into the Tebrau Straits was proof that all humans had similar desires, even if they had different cultures. (19)

Their cultural openness and flexibility are depicted as worthy of emulation even if they have been viewed by some as backward and "uncivilized" due to their lack of settlement and animist beliefs. The novel stakes a claim about the universal applicability of the Orang Seletar's socially harmonious philosophy and non-exploitative way of life while simultaneously highlighting the particularity of the group's geocultural existence.

Central to the novel's archipelagic thinking and lament about the historical displacement of Singapore's original inhabitants is a loss measured in ecological terms – the destruction of natural habitat, the loss of mangrove swamps, and, no less tangibly, an impoverishment of the environmental imagination. While the text may be overly didactic at times in its exposition of history, it employs a different register and tone to evoke a sensuous, bucolic, and lush natural world that only the Orang Seletar were privy to with their archipelagic mobility and closeness to the coastlines. This is intimated in the way Rawa is frequently drawn to noticing, for example, the mangroves, the nyireh trees, and the berembang trees along the river bank. On a trip to the Pulai estuary in their *pau kajang* (a traditional wooden houseboat), Rawa and his family revel in untouched natural surroundings seemingly overlooked by modern developments: "They looked at Merambong Island far in the distance, opposite the river mouth, and the large bed of seaweed between it and the estuary, rich in dugongs, seahorses, turtles and all sorts of fish amongst the corals" (Isa [2009] 2013, 71). Once in the water, Rawa loosens his grip to allow his young daughter, Kuntum, to swim with a school of dugongs in the "crystal river water" (71). In that natural space, Rawa's family encounters other animals like otters, seahorses, and monkeys in the surrounding trees. They also see another indigenous group who, while not sea nomads like the Orang Seletar, "lived in harmony with the jungle and the rivers" (72). This non-diegetic, idyllic, and romanticized scene in the novel of human and other-than-human existence offers readers a glimpse of more ecologically sustainable possibilities in the Anthropocene.

Rawa's life, in contrast to what he calls the "rational culture" (Isa [2009] 2013, 134) of modern nationhood and urban living, had always been about "living by his instinct, one with the forest, animals, rivers and seas" (133). Despite his death at the end, the novel's conclusion is hopeful as Rawa's missing emerald ring is miraculously returned to his grandson, Hassan. In aspiring to be a naval engineer and ship builder, Hassan is represented as symbolically continuing the history of the Orang Seletar into the present,

transmuting the group's traditional archipelagic thinking and water-based life into heritage more closely aligned with modern national goals pertaining to commerce and defence.

The Great Reclamation

Heng identified *Rawa* as one of the books she read in preparation for writing her novel *The Great Reclamation*, and, like *Rawa*, Heng's work sets out to weigh the affective, sociocultural, and ecological cost of Singapore's transformation from colony to independent, postcolonial polity. It laments the country's severance from the past as necessary for its modernity, a rationalization captured in the preface quotation from S. Rajaratnam, composer of the nation's pledge and one of the key figures in founding Prime Minister Lee Kuan Yew's cabinet, who had observed in 1968: "We do not lay undue stress on the past. We do not see nation-building and modernization as primarily an exercise in reuniting the present generation with a past generation and its values and glories" (Heng 2023, n.p.). Indeed, as the novel reveals, a critical component of the island's new identity as a sovereign postcolonial nation would consist of reclaiming land from the sea to expand its territorial size for economic development, thereby altering its coastline forever. Two "forms of construction" have always been at work historically: "the physical construction of a state" and the "construction of a narrative – a story – to guide Singaporeans into a prosperous and desirable future" (Novak 2020, 72). Land reclamation was first carried out by the British colonial government in 1822 but greatly accelerated and expanded under the PAP-led postcolonial government to the extent that Singapore today is about 25 percent larger than it was 200 years ago (see Jamieson 2017; Lim 2017). The text weaves into this national expansion narrative a conceit about magical islands appearing and disappearing according to the phases of the moon to signify the loss of ecological plenitude and the surrendering of an archipelagic imagination to the hard-nosed, pragmatic logic lacing Singapore's modernization and nationalism.

Heng's novel covers Singapore's history from 1941 to 1963 and features tumultuous events like the Japanese occupation of Singapore during World War II, the post-war struggle for independence, the clash between Chinese-educated leftists and communists and the colonial and postcolonial governments, the Malayan Emergency, and the attainment of independence through merger in 1963 as "Malaysia". These historical events shape the lives of the text's main character, Lee Ah Boon, his immediate family, the girl he loves, Siok Mei, and the fishing families of his kampong (or village) on the "southeastern shore of the territory they called Singapore" (Heng 2023, 19). As a young boy, Ah Boon is hesitant about becoming a fisherman like his father but, on his first fishing trip out to sea with his father and brother, he realizes his preternatural ability to discover islands which attract shoals of fish that are easily caught.

Driving the novel's main plot are Ah Boon's deepening feelings for Siok Mei, his classmate from the village school with whom he falls in love. Their relationship develops against the backdrop of key events in Singapore history: the Maria Hertogh riots, protests against compulsory conscription, decolonization and the struggle for independence, the crackdown on leftist students and activists, and the Malayan Emergency. Siok Mei's involvement with Chinese-speaking leftist and communist activists strains her

relationship with Ah Boon. She eventually marries a fellow activist, Eng Soon, while Ah Boon joins the Gah Men (a neologism that is a transliteration and approximation of how Chinese speakers pronounce "government")[5] and finds work in the new community centre built in their kampong.

If *Rawa* seeks to add to public memory by recuperating a pre-colonial and pre-national Singapore where its waterways and coasts in relation to Johor and other islands were a defining part of its place identity, *The Great Reclamation* has a different aim. The latter traces how pragmatism and land-based rationality take root in Singapore, usurping a private affective economy of innocence and fidelity to the past that is symbolized in the novel by self-sustaining dependence on the sea and the existence of a magical rather than literal archipelago. From the start, change is the main thematic concern of the text, evident as the narrator discloses the many names of the island: "Temasek, Pulau Ujong, Nanyang, Sin Chew, Singapura, Singapore, depending on who and when you asked" (Heng 2023, 19). The multiple names index the island's mutable identity, underscoring how the latter is a function of history and a projection of collective desires, ideals, and realities.

Historical change gathers pace after World War II with disruptive change in the form of extensive land reclamation in the southeast and eastern parts of the island. This project alters the coastline, the mud flats, and the ecological landscape irrevocably, bringing resettlement of the kampong folk. In the eyes of Ma, Ah Boon's mother, change is accretive but inexorable and profound: "First the CC [Community Centre], then the land reclamation project, then perhaps merger and full independence. She could smell the change in the air, and could feel the ground shifting beneath her feet" (Heng 2023, 290). The building of a new community centre in the kampong represents the first tangible encroachment by the state into the lives of Ah Boon and his neighbours. Initially, the kampong by the sea was a marginal location shielded from happenings in the city, since "the country was the city" (195) and "as long as the Gah Men remained in the city, the kampong could remain suspended in the gelatinous fluids of their unchanging lives" (196). Here, community had arisen from long time coexistence, mutual help, and slowly nurtured familiarity. However, with its TV, modern toilet, and newspapers, the community centre heralds a different form of community-building operating according to an alternative logic from the organic relationships in the kampong; one that is systematic, rationalized, and signifies the state's increasing reach as "gradually the CC was absorbed into the daily rhythms of kampong life, as a foreign sapling might grow intertwined with resident root systems of an old swamp" (247). This is a re-territorialization promising proto-national unification and standardization with greater bureaucracy and the increasing use of English.

Notably, the text stresses the all-encompassing radical, and even ruthless, nature of change and how it occurs somatically and viscerally at the individual level. Thus, Ah Boon assumes the habitus of a "Gah Man"[6] once he starts working for the CC – he carries himself differently, speaks English "with the clipped, precise enunciation of the newly educated" (Heng 2023, 306), and "smelled like citrus" (284) rather than the ocean. The measure of Ah Boon's full transformation as a character, however, hinges on his relationship with the sea. As a child, he feared being engulfed by the ocean, which he saw as potentially treacherous and as "straight out of his worst nightmares, a sea come alive with invisible beings that would pull him into unknown depths" (85). Once, faint from fear, he

forced himself to step into a sea of fish to get into his father's boat: "A single fish squirmed under the arch of his foot, trapped against the shifting sand. Ah Boon gritted his teeth and ground his heel down against the muscular flesh of the fish" (86). Young Ah Boon's show of resolve here foreshadows his later actions as an adult when he ruthlessly conquers fear and doubt about the future by forcibly turning the sea itself into more predictable matter with land reclamation, as the title of Section IV proclaims: "Fill the Earth and Subdue It." Through his employment at the CC and later as a member of the Citizens Working Group, Ah Boon prospers, marries the English-speaking "Gah Woman", Natalie, and becomes an owner of land-based property. Around him, his mother, brother, and former kampong neighbours also become urban subjects when dispersed from the coast and rehoused in flats, an interpellation neatly encapsulated by his brother giving up fishing for a more lucrative land job in construction.

According to Maria Margaronis (2008), all historical fiction occupies a "no-man's land on the borders of fact and fantasy" (138). *The Great Reclamation* embodies this quite literally by countering the land-based, government-sanctioned historical narrative of the nation with the fantastical as represented by the magic-realist trope of islands that appear and disappear, the idea of mysterious islands being common in Malay legends and also featured in some contemporary novels about the region.[7] Like the mythical cornucopia or horn of plenty, the islands bring in their wake the bounty of the sea for the kampong fisherfolk to catch. The first island appears when young Ah Boon accompanies his father and brother out to sea on his inaugural trip. The island they see has cliffs and rises up from the sea like "a giant humpbacked monster" (Heng 2023, 7). Ah Boon finds himself drawn to the sea and fishing after that, less afraid of the water. He thinks that the "island made the sea comprehensible, less boundless, more known" (23). As a fabulist conceit of the novel, the mysterious islands serve various functions. To Ah Boon, they are associated with childhood, sensuous innocence, wonder, love of family, and the promise of inter-generational inheritance. His discovery of the first island together with his father and brother becomes in time a memory of familial intimacy. In the case of the kampong folk once they too have been let in on the secret, the islands foster community and sustain them, especially during the war years. The islands and the teeming waters around them appear to be the world of the fishermen transmogrified. Yet they are mercurial and fickle and only Ah Boon can reliably find them at first. As magical as the islands are, they are also not invulnerable to external forces and historical change. They are affected by events like the Japanese occupation, and, later, by the ecologically disruptive processes of land reclamation and the construction of multistorey flats. The reverberations from these events cause the islands to disappear and reduce the catch of fish available. The changes to the islands also point to Ah Boon's own transformation into a pragmatic advocate for the government as he starts to turn his back on the past including Siok Mei.

The novel's plot intertwines the Singapore state's land reclamation project with the history of its suppression of leftist and communist Chinese elements including members of the political parties Barisan Sosialis and Partai Rakyat during Operation Cold Store prior to the merger with Malaysia. Together they convey the pragmatic and efficient logic of the postcolonial PAP government's will to power and control. When Siok Mei's husband, Eng Soon, is detained by the government and imprisoned, Ah Boon hides her on one of the magical islands which, temporarily at least, becomes a self-contained and private Edenic site for the fulfilment of his desire for her. In the end, however, when Siok Mei will not

give up Eng Soon, and Ah Boon sees that no future with her is possible, he betrays her to the authorities in bitterness. He compounds that betrayal by leading the authorities to the magical islands so that these can be mined for the sand needed to complete the island's land reclamation works, a practical and neat solution first thought of by Natalie. Ah Boon's destruction of the magical archipelago through his treatment of the islands as a geo-engineering resource to be exploited for fill material is emblematic of the loss of his innocence and connection to the past. Creating solid ground for "soaring, majestic blocks of flats" (Heng 2023, 331) where the sea once was reflects the state's prosaic and pragmatic land-based rationality at work, one where nature can always be manipulated as with government-initiated tree-planting, "the earth-binding roots being the mechanism by which the newly created land would solidify and settle" (444). As the narrator notes,

> [land reclamation] was elegant in its simplicity, shameless in its daring, as most of the Gah Men's plans were. Squatters? Move them. Communists? Jail them. Housing? Build it. Even the earth itself was malleable, the constraints of geography surmountable. (321)

Land reclamation serves as a "projection of sovereignty" (Jamieson 2021, 278), irrevocably altering people's association with seascapes and landscapes while forming new "affective geographies of sentimentality" (Lowe 2024, n.p.). The island nation is thus forged by extricating and disidentifying it from its archipelagic setting to emphasize its singularity and exceptionalism.[8] Historically, in Singapore, land reclamation by the postcolonial state began in earnest in 1966 after a pilot project at Bedok in 1963. The "Great Reclamation" refers to the extensive land reclamation project of the eastern coast of the island which was implemented in stages over 30 years from the 1960s to the 1990s.

While the novel's title alludes to the land reclamation project central to Singapore's nationhood, the text as a whole attempts a symbolically significant reclamation of the sea, a sense of fidelity to the past, and a related sense of wonder. By using the conceit of mysterious islands, Heng shows herself inspired by archipelagic thinking to question how something magical can become "plain matter" (2023, 92), as a young Ah Boon once mused. The magical islands in the novel are fragile, heterotopic spaces that stand partially outside historical time and nation-building reality; they bring to mind how magic realism as an "aesthetic practice" problematizes time and "forces us to re-think the structures of nation-ness itself" (Pérez 2020, 467). In causing their ultimate destruction and allowing the homogeneous time of the nation state to triumph, Ah Boon's imaginative and emotional world shrinks, a price he recognizes but which he wills himself to accept. That private sense of loss is made coterminous with Singapore's attainment of independence as an island nation when the narrator observes at the end, through the use of prolepsis, how Singapore will leave Malaysia after only two years to begin "its longer life as an island without its hinterland, its heart without its body" (446).

Conclusion: Archipelagic pasts for archipelagic futures

Archipelagic thinking in the Malay-language text *Rawa* serves to dislodge the dominant centrality of Singapore's orthodox nationalist narrative by recovering the history of the marginalized Orang Seletar and validating their more sustainable, ecologically conscious traditional way of living. In *The Great Reclamation*, the allegorical device of bountiful seas and mysterious magical islands evokes a lost plentitude in ecological as well as imaginative

terms. The text connects two foundational events in Singapore's history as a nation – land reclamation and the postcolonial state's crackdown on communism and left-wing dissenters – suggesting that the same expedient but hubristic and authoritarian ethos was at work in both cases. Each novel focuses on an ethnically different littoral community whose spatio-temporal realities as well as historical ways of knowing and being were disrupted by the postcolonial nation state's relentless pursuit of modernization. Archipelagic thinking seeks to overcome the narrow frames of reference imposed by a state-sanctioned history invested in such a monological, teleological narrativization of nation-building. In lamenting the personal, sociocultural, and environmental cost of Singapore's development trajectory, *Rawa* and *The Great Reclamation* mount a trenchant critique of the national tendency towards unsentimental pragmatism and exceptionalism founded on a land-focused nation-building rationality. But gesturing beyond critique, they also underscore the importance of archipelagic thinking to expand the national imaginary by embracing the sea as a site of symbolic and affective power while simultaneously insisting on the island-nation's entanglement in a shared terraqueous ecology and regional geography.

Notes

1. Before the Anglo Dutch treaty of 1824 which split the Malay world into areas of control by the British and Dutch respectively, Singapore and the rest of the Riau-Lingga archipelago were ruled as part of the Johor Sultanate which emerged from the fall of the Melaka Sultanate to the Portuguese in 1511. For an account of the indigenous political economy in Singapore and Johor in the 18th and 19th centuries, which challenges European colonial historiography, see Trocki (2007).
2. Singapore has four official languages – English, Malay, Mandarin Chinese, and Tamil. The three non-English languages are considered "mother tongue" languages. English is the first language and Malay is the national language.
3. See, for instance, Ryan (2017) and Santa Ana et al. (2022).
4. The dispute between the two countries arose in 1979 when Malaysia claimed several islets including Pedra Branca and the Middle Rocks within its territorial waters. In 2008, the International Court of Justice (ICJ) ruled that Pedra Branca belonged to Singapore while the Middle Rocks were Malaysia's. In 2017, Malaysia filed an application to review the ICJ ruling but subsequently withdrew it the following year.
5. The word may be deliberately pronounced as such for sardonic effect depending on the context.
6. In the novel, Heng also uses the terms "Gah Man" and "Gah Woman" to mean "government man" and "government woman" respectively. These are understood to be government officials or civil servants.
7. The novel *Penghulu* by Malay writer Suratman Markasan (([1998] 2012); translated into English in 2012) features a disappearing island while characters in Tash Aw's (2005) *The Harmony Silk Factory* sail to the Seven Maidens, an enigmatic group of islands.
8. Lowe argues that through land reclamation, Singapore is able to "*project* a distinctive form of 'temperateness' in tropical Southeast Asia that is evocative of geographical anatropism" (2024, n.p.; author's emphasis) where the tropics and temperate zones are conceptual rather than purely cartographic spaces.

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